Health Centers: A Guide for Patients

What Are Health Centers?

- Health centers are local clinics that can treat your medical, dental, and other health care needs. They are community-based and led in part by patients at the health center. Health centers focus on meeting the needs of the people and the areas they serve.

- Health centers have been a key part of the nation's health care system for 60 years. They serve more than 32.4 million people at more than 16,200 sites across the country. About 90% of their patients have incomes less than 200% of the federal poverty level.

- They are in all U.S. states, territories, and the District of Columbia. You can find them in cities, rural areas, and everywhere in between. Health centers are located where people can access them easily. Some health centers also operate mobile vans to bring care directly to patients.

- They have doctors, dentists, therapists, social workers, eye doctors, OB/GYNs, pediatricians, case managers, and other medical professionals who ensure that patients receive a full range of care.

- Health centers adjust their fees based on income and family size. Even if you don't have insurance or can't afford to pay, you will not be turned away.

- Many health centers help with transportation if you have trouble traveling to a clinic in your area.

- Health centers are partly funded by the Health Resources and Services Administration (HRSA). HRSA monitors health centers to ensure they meet high standards and help their patients achieve better health.

- Health centers provide high-quality care. According to a recent survey, 97% of patients would recommend their health center to family or friends.

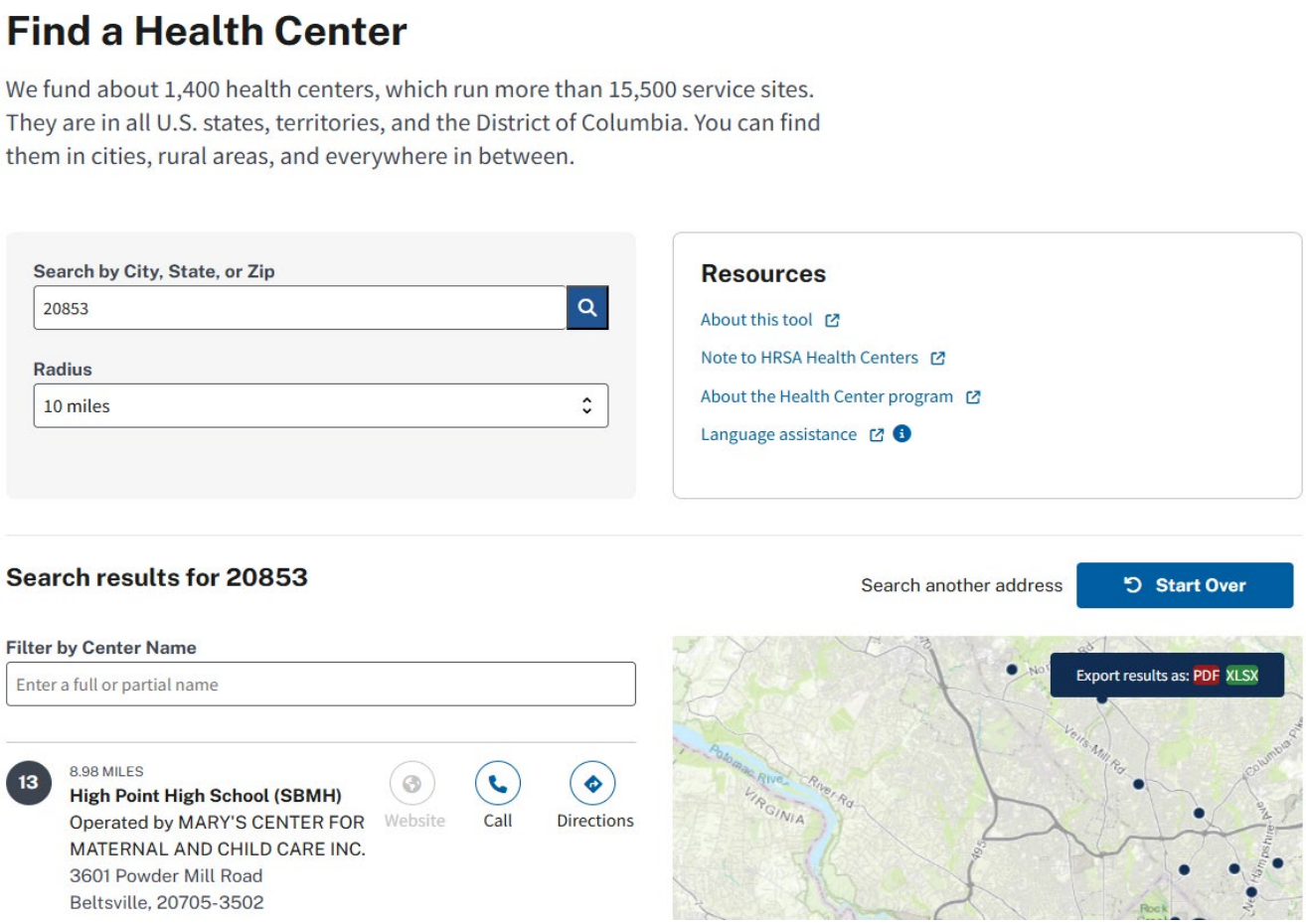
What Health Centers Do

Health centers may provide some or all of the following services:

- Blood pressure monitoring
- Cancer screening
- Prenatal care
- Care for infants and children
- Dental exams
- Dental sealants for children
- Diabetes monitoring and treatment
- Eye exams
- Health education
- Hepatitis tests
- HIV tests
- Mammograms
- Mental health counseling
- Pap tests
- Physicals
- Smoking counseling
- Statin therapy for heart disease
- Substance use counseling
- Vaccines
- Well-child visits

Many health centers also have on-site pharmacies and can provide discounted prescription drugs.

How to Find a Health Center

Go to https://findahealthcenter.hrsa.gov/.

Enter your location to find a health center clinic near you. The site provides contact information and directions to each location.